Your Google profile, *telling your story.*

When someone looks your business up on Google or Maps, that profile is often the first part of your brand they see: the name, the photos, the hours, what people say about you. This guide shows you how to set it up properly, step by step, so it says the same thing as your sign, your website and your social media. You can do it yourself, in an afternoon.

WHO IT'S FOR	TIME	WHAT YOU NEED	WHERE
Businesses with a location, or that go to their customers	An afternoon, then 15 minutes a month	A Google account, your logo and real photos	business.google.com

> Your Google profile is another face of your brand. Make it look and sound *like everything else.*

THE BASICS: THAT IT EXISTS, THAT IT'S YOURS AND THAT IT TELLS THE TRUTH

1 Claim it or create it

Your business may already be on Google even if you never created it.

- Go to **business.google.com** and search for your business. If it already exists, **claim it** instead of creating another one: duplicate profiles confuse people.
- Use a Google account that belongs to **the business**, not an employee's personal one.
- Add a second trusted person as an owner or manager, so you never lose access.

2 Verify it

Until it's verified, your changes don't go live.

- Google will tell you how to verify. Today it usually asks for **a short video, recorded in one take**, with no cuts.
- Show your sign or storefront, the place where you work or your tools, and something that proves you're in charge (unlocking the door or the register, for example).
- The review can take a few days. Meanwhile, don't change the name or the address.

3 The name, as it is

Exactly as it appears on your sign, your website and your invoices.

- No keywords, city names, slogans, phone numbers or all caps. Google can suspend a profile for that.

```
✓ Corner Café
✗ Corner Café | Best Coffee in Austin
```

4 Where you are

It depends on whether customers come to you or you go to them.

- **If customers visit you:** your exact address. P.O. boxes and virtual offices aren't allowed.
- **If you go to your customers** (deliveries, home services): hide the address and set your service area, up to about two hours' drive.

What *your brand says*

This is where the profile stops being a listing and starts to sound like you. Use the same words, the same colors and the same tone as on your website and social media.

5 The primary category

It's the most important decision in the profile.

- Choose the **most specific** one that describes what you **are**, not what you have: "Coffee shop", not "Free Wi-Fi".
- Add only a few more, and only if they're a core part of the business.

6 Hours, phone and website

What people check most, and what annoys them most when it's wrong.

- Enter your real hours and use **special hours** for holidays and time off.
- A phone number that you or your team actually answer.
- Your own website. If you don't have one yet, leave it empty rather than linking to something that isn't yours.

7 The description, in your voice

Up to 750 characters, with no links, prices or promotions.

- Tell where your brand comes from, what you do, for whom and what makes you different. Write it the way you talk to your customers.

```
[Your brand] was born in [year] because
[the reason].
We make [what] for [whom].
What makes us different is [what].
```

8 Photos with your identity

Real, well lit, and in the same style as your social media.

- **Logo:** the same one as on your social media, in a square format.
- **Cover, storefront and interior:** so people recognize you when they arrive.
- **Products, services and team:** what your brand makes and who makes it.
- No photos from the internet, no text on top, no filters that change your colors.

9 Products and services

The list of what you offer, with the same names as your menu or your website.

- If your menu calls it "House coffee", call it that on Google too.
- Tick the **attributes** you really have: wheelchair access, card payments, Wi-Fi.

10 Reviews, in your voice

What others say about you is part of your brand too.

- Ask **every** customer, using the "Ask for reviews" link in your profile.
- Never pay for them or offer anything in return, and don't ask only the happy ones: Google forbids it.
- Reply to all of them, the bad ones too: thank them, acknowledge it and offer to sort it out privately.

Keep it alive

An up-to-date profile says the business is alive. Fifteen minutes a month is enough.

- Check your hours, photos and details once a month, and before every holiday.
- Google and other people can **suggest edits** to your profile: review them and accept only the right ones.
- Share updates with your own photos: a new product, an event, a change of hours.

The *coherence test*

Open your Google profile next to your website and your social media, and tick what matches. Whatever doesn't match is the first thing to fix.

IS IT THE SAME EVERYWHERE?

- [ ] **The name**, written the same on your sign, your website, your social media and Google.
- [ ] **The logo**: the same version and the same colors.
- [ ] **The hours**, holidays included.
- [ ] **The phone and WhatsApp** you actually answer.
- [ ] **The address**, or the area you serve.
- [ ] **The way you talk**: the description sounds like your posts.
- [ ] **The photos** share the style of your social media.
- [ ] **The names** of your products and services match on your menu, your website and Google.

> A well-made profile promises nothing: *it tells the truth about your brand*, like everything else.

And when you want to go *further*

This guide puts one part of your brand in order. If one day you want everything to tell the same story (your identity, your website, your social media), we start with your MIRA, with no commitment.

Your MIRA
16ballcreations.com/en/mira
Write to us
crea@16ballcreations.com